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Language Policy and Latina Immigrants: An Analysis of Personal Experience and Identity in Interview Talk

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This article examines how Spanish-speaking Latina (im)migrants position themselves relative to US language policies. Drawing from interviews with 15 Latin American women in the USA, we illustrate how understandings of language policy are constructed through individuals' reports of everyday experiences and framed within the constraints of contemporary language politics and ideological debates. Building on recent shifts in language policy research towards the study of how individuals engage with language policy issues, we argue for a close analysis of interview talk as a way of gaining important insights into this issue. Data from the study not only illustrate the existence of multiple frames for individual understandings of language policy, but also suggest how these discussions become terrains for the personal negotiation of identities within a broader socio-political context that is overwhelmingly anti-immigrant.

Like much of the field of applied linguistics, scholarship within the area of language planning and policy (LPP) dates back to the late 1950s. While LPP scholarship is less than five decades old and has only recently developed into an organized field of study, it has undergone three substantial, paradigmatic shifts (Ricento 2000). Early LPP work (e.g. Fishman *et al.* 1968; Rubin and Jernudd 1971) tended to focus on efforts to resolve 'language problems', typically in post-colonial and economically developing nation-states, through positivist, technocratic, and linguistic solutions based on the effective management of linguistic resources. By the late 1970s, as it became apparent that the development (and language policy) efforts in these nations often failed to achieve their aims (Spolsky 2009) and that core language policy constructs such as 'diglossia' and 'native speaker' were far from neutral (e.g. Davies 1991; Woolard and Schieffelin 1994), LPP turned its focus to the role of language—and language policy in particular—in reproducing social and economic inequality both within and across nation-states. The current phase of LPP work, rooted in the 1990s, greatly expands these critical approaches as LPP research has focused on personal agency and emphasized the ways in which language policy interacts with individual and collective language ideologies and politics as well as with global forces such as large-scale

migration, minority language endangerment, and linguistic human rights struggles.

Within this third paradigm, LPP research recently has focused greater attention on how individuals interpret and engage with language policies, and how they position themselves relative to those policies and to language politics more generally across a wide range of contexts (e.g. Canagarajah 2005; Warriner 2007; Johnson 2009). This greater focus on personal agency and individual experience is essential if we are to begin to answer the central (and still largely unaddressed) LPP question of 'Why do individuals opt to use (or cease to use) particular languages and varieties for specified functions in different domains' and how those choices influence—and are influenced by—'institutional language policy decision-making?' (Ricento 2000: 208). Such a focus on individual experiences and understandings moves us beyond language policy analysis of official documents as technocratic solutions. Instead, attention shifts towards analysis of reported language practices and discursive understandings of those practices as a ground for analysis of the mechanisms through which individuals and institutions shape—and are shaped by—language policy and the broader political climate.

The present article builds on this expanding body of work by examining how individuals who we argue are among the implicit, and at times explicit, targets of US language policy—that is non- or limited English-speaking Latina (im)migrants—experience and position themselves relative to US language policy and politics. We take language policy to be deliberate, state, or institutionally sponsored efforts to influence the behavior of others with respect to the acquisition, structure, or functional allocation of language(s) (Cooper 1989), and language politics to be the political, social, and cultural consequences of such efforts. Our aim is to investigate how these women construct understandings of both the language policies and language politics that surround them, and how they relate these issues to personal identity within interviews. Considerable language policy research seeks to examine the impact of language policies targeting (im)migrant and language minority populations (e.g. Hult 2004; Gándara and Rumberger 2009). Our approach differs in that we center our analysis on women's reported experiences and understandings of language policy and politics, not on the merit or effectiveness of specific language policies.

THE WIDER FRAME: LANGUAGE POLICY AND LANGUAGE IDEOLOGIES IN THE USA

Discourses about language both among and about immigrants in the USA cannot be meaningfully analyzed without a general understanding of how immigration and language are politically linked and racially charged. Indeed, in the USA, language policy debates are key sites of ideological struggle as they imply the legitimization or de-legitimization of languages and their users (e.g. Ricento 2000; Tollefson 2002; Crawford 2008; García 2008). A central

aim of LPP work in recent years has been to shed light on the ideological forces that have shaped the formation and implementation of these policies (e.g. Hornberger and Johnson 2007; Hult 2007; Rubdy 2008). Within the USA, many of the debates directly or indirectly concern Spanish and implicate politics and policies of immigration generally, and Mexican and Latin American immigration in particular. Ongoing points of contention, for instance, include whether Spanish is a legitimate language of communication in schools, offices, and public domains and under what circumstances Spanish speakers have the right to use their language in public settings, such as work and healthcare (e.g. Martinez 2008), as well as in private settings such as personal cars and homes. Often, the implicit or explicit targets of these policies are Latina immigrants. For instance, recent high-profile cases include Ernestina Mondragon's court appeal in Dallas, Texas, for having been ticketed for being a 'non English-speaking driver' (Goldstein 2009), and multiple cases in which maternal competency and custody have been challenged on the grounds of limited English proficiency (e.g. Barry 2005; Padgett and Mascareñas 2009).

These and other language policy cases are profoundly shaped by long-standing mainstream language ideologies—widely in evidence in both popular and political discourse—that link migration status and language proficiency and equate learning English with being 'good immigrants' (e.g. Brandeis 1915; Griswold 2005; Woutat 2010). English is framed as both a prerequisite for personal success and as an easily accessible tool for learning (Haviland 2003). In this way, English use can be understood as a central component of banal nationalism (Billig 1995), as it is strategically employed to define who is (and who is not) a member of the national community. Since knowing English is connected with both '*becoming* and *being* American', English proficiency tends to serve as an index of nationalism and patriotism (Warriner 2007: 345). In turn, lack of English proficiency and maintenance of a non-English language is often taken as an individual deficiency and a sign of lack of personal commitment to the USA or 'American' values (Pavlenko 2002). These language ideologies are interwoven with broader discourses on Latin American migration to the USA that are overwhelmingly negative. (Im)migrants conduct their lives within a political and social climate in which immigration is politicized and racialized, and in which the individuality, humanity, and positive contributions of migrant workers are diminished.

As Santa Ana (1999), among others, has documented, US public discourse on immigrants is profoundly racist and de-humanizing. As a result, many US citizens regard immigrants as criminals. Recently, a 2008 *New York Times/CBS News* poll found that 69 per cent of American adults believe illegal immigrants should 'be prosecuted and deported for being in the US illegally' (Rasmussen Reports 2007). Data also suggests that 52 per cent of adults believe that most recent immigrants 'cause problems' and 62 per cent think that immigrants do not make enough of an effort to learn English (Rasmussen Reports 2007). Such stances do not go unnoticed by US Latinos, and indeed the

majority now perceive themselves to be the targets of bias (MacGregor-Mendoza 1998; Pew Hispanic Center 2007).

These ideologies and debates are a prominent component of US political life and are high-stakes for the individual (im)migrants who are being 'debated'. Furthermore, recent research suggests that widespread expectations concerning language often contradict the experiences of many (im)migrants, who face great challenges in learning English and, even if successful in acquiring it, often fail to achieve their aspirations in the USA (Warriner 2007). Ideologies of language and discourses of immigration thus shape the personal experiences of individual learners as well as their investment in language programs (Skilton-Sylvester 2002). Nevertheless, little research directly examines how immigrants who are the targets of such language policies and implicit subjects of these language politics view and understand them. Given the tight connections that link language ideologies, language policies, and (im)migration, more attention is warranted to how individual (im)migrants position themselves as (im)migrants, speakers, and residents within this context and how they make sense of the multiple and contradictory discourses that surround them.

THE STUDY

In this article we focus on a group that thus far has received little academic attention: transnational Latin American (im)migrant women who have contingent legal status, often no US legal documentation at all, and typically limited contact with English-speakers. As such, the women in our study are among the most marginalized of US workers (Hondagneu-Sotelo 2001), with little job security, few to no legal recourses, and minimal institutional or governmental support (Vellos 1997). We selected members of this group in part because, working in domestic spheres, out of public view, their voices are often excluded from both political and academic discussions.

We chose to focus our study on women for several reasons. First, migration studies, and in particular those centered on Latin American (im)migrants, have stressed the important role women play in the key migration decisions (Miles 2003). Other work (e.g. Hondagneu-Sotelo 2001) emphasizes the critical functions of women with respect to transactions at stores, schools, and workplaces. Moreover, an established line of sociolinguistic research points to the significance of women's participation in processes of linguistic shift and maintenance (e.g. Gal 1978; Holmes 1993; Winter and Pauwels 2005). Yet, despite the prominent role of women in these domains, there has been very little exploration of their language ideologies, their investments in English, and their stances towards language policy (an exception being Relaño-Pastor and De Fina 2005). Finally, as suggested above, Latina women are often the real and imagined targets of language policies. For instance, all of the legal rulings with respect to parental English language competencies have involved mothers; and, Latina women are frequently the targets of English-only workplace sanctions (Baldas 2007).

Participants

Participants for the present study were 15 women from Latin America working in the Washington, DC metropolitan area. Like millions of individuals living in the USA, they are best described as 'contingent citizens' (Boehm 2008), as they, or members of their immediate family, lack permanent legal residence. Contingent citizenship 'is national membership that is shifting, partial, conditional, or relational', including 'undocumented residents of the USA who are *de facto* members by virtue of their employment, education, residence, political participation, and civic engagement' (Boehm 2008: 3–4). Holders of G-5, A-3, and B-1 visas are also contingent citizens because, for these individuals, legal residence in the USA entirely depends on maintenance of their current employment within one private family home.[1]

The women were all born outside the USA and their ages ranged from 28 to 55 years, with most in their 40s (see Appendix 1 available as online supplementary material). All had lived in the country for at least 4 years, with some moving back and forth several times between the USA and their home country. Reflecting the Latino diversity of the Washington, DC area, the women represented a wide geographic swath, hailing from Mexico (2), Bolivia (3), Colombia (2), El Salvador (5), Chile (1), Ecuador (1), and Peru (1). With the exception of one secretary and one receptionist, all worked in private domestic spheres, cleaning houses or minding children—jobs that are performed in isolated and dispersed conditions (Hondagneu-Sotelo 2001). Most of our participants had restricted opportunities for formal schooling in the USA, although many had intermittently attended weekly English-as-a-second-language or Spanish-language literacy classes, both of which were typically church-based. All spoke Spanish as their first language and were Spanish dominant or Spanish monolinguals, but their particular varieties differed by place of origin. The majority of the women we interviewed had little to no need to use English in their work or social lives.

Interviews and analysis

Our focus here was on talk surrounding language policy, and on gaining participants' perspectives relative to the issues outlined above. Given the physical and social isolation of our participants, opportunities for ethnographically grounded, naturalistic interactions were nonexistent. As detailed above, the great majority of the women in our study spent nearly all of their waking hours alone or in the company of young children. Given these restrictions, the talk analyzed here was collected through informal interviews. As our aim was to investigate how individuals understand and talk about language policies, interviews were an appropriate approach to data collection.

All interviews touched on a similar range of topics (Appendix 2 available as online supplementary material), focusing on participants' personal history of migration and experiences with language learning, use, and policy.

Participants were also encouraged to expand on topics, experiences, and sentiments of interest and importance to them. Women were recruited through personal and professional networks, including participants in prior studies. In some cases, the interview and interviewer had known each other personally over multiple years, while in others instances, they were recent acquaintances. Interviews ranged from 30 to 90 min, with most lasting about an hour. Researchers explained to the participants that they were interested in their life as immigrants and in how they had dealt with language issues. All interviews took place at a location of the participants' choosing, typically either in the participant's place of work or a nearby café, and were conducted and transcribed in Spanish.

Interviews have a long—and at points problematic and contentious—history within applied linguistics research. The interview has mainly been treated as a research instrument (Talmy 2010), that is, as a means for investigating particular content, truths, facts, beliefs, or attitudes. A well-established alternative approach, and the one taken here, treats the research interviews as a type of social practice (Cicourel 1964; Briggs 1986; Rapley 2001) wherein *both* the *content* of the talk and the *interactional processes* between the interviewer and interviewee constructing that content are investigated (Zilles and King 2005; Talmy 2010). More specifically, we approach interviews as sense-making events in which interviewers and interviewees participate with different levels of context being brought to bear. On the one hand, the interaction between the participants serves as a site for the positioning of self and other with respect to identity and relational issues. For instance, in our interviews we tended to align ourselves with participants and to try to build on common ground. As evident in the transcripts below, we mainly listened and often expressed agreement with the points made by interviewees; for their part, interviewees often seemed keen to establish a positive rapport with us given our interest in what they had to say. But involvement or distance between the participants and levels of formality varied according to the relationships between interviewer and interviewee, the topics that questions raised, and the emergent shape of the event. In that sense, the participation framework of each interview is unique and the nuances of individual interactions cannot be adequately captured in a discussion of general trends in discourse about policy. On the other hand, it is important to stress that the discourse between participants presupposes, evokes, and implicates legal and social processes and practices relevant to the material life of immigrants as well as discourses and ideologies about migration and language. Such discourses in turn impact the local construction of identities since interviewers and interviewees deal with circulating images of what it means to be a Latina, or a domestic worker, or alternatively a researcher, and adjust to each other in order to negotiate the self images that they want to project.

Our premise is that close examination of how these contexts are entrenched in concrete social interactions potentially yields a deeper understanding of people's reactions to public policies. Such an approach implies considering

the role of both interviewer and interviewee in the analysis of sequences of talk and determining to what extent such roles are oriented to and made relevant by participants. Thus, our analysis draws from past work illustrating how interviews constitute interactional occasions in which participants share personal knowledge and experiences, position themselves relative to such content through their linguistic and discursive choices and project different identities. As argued in past work, it is indeed through the negotiation of personal experience and of social meanings that people build personhood and identities (De Fina 2003; Triandafyllidou and Wodak 2003; De Fina *et al.* 2006; Krzyżanowski and Wodak 2008). Thus, interviews were analyzed along several dimensions. We identified and analyzed narrative fragments, that is, recounting of past experience focused on language difficulty or conflict (see De Fina and King in press). We also coded interview exchanges based on theme and topic according to whether they were descriptions and discussions of language difficulty, language policy, ethnic tensions, or immigration policy, collaboratively refining categories as we proceeded. We engaged in a general analysis of these recurrent topics and themes in order to identify similarities and differences in ways in which participants developed and negotiated them in the interviews. In addition, we conducted analyses of each individual interview, looking closely at identity construction and management. This approach, which allowed us to move back and forth between detailed analysis of each individual interview and comparative analysis of broader themes and trends, provides the background for the analysis that we present here focusing on question–answer sequences concerning language policy.

FINDINGS AND DISCUSSION

While past research has emphasized the ways in which language policy *formation* is ideologically driven (e.g. Ricento 2006), our data illustrate how language policy discussions often become terrains for *engagement* with language ideologies. As we demonstrate below, most women interpreted and understood language policy on the basis of their everyday observations and interactions, but also used it as a tool for self-presentation and self-positioning within the broader anti-immigrant context of public discourse in the USA.

Language policy and immigrant identities

As 'impossible subjects' (Ngai 2004), that is long-term residents who are fully employed yet are simultaneously constructed through US legal and ideological machinery as less than legitimate members of US society, (im)migrant women are left with few options in presenting themselves relative to US language policy and politics. At the simplest level, their choices are to position themselves as individuals who try to belong, accepting the need and importance of English and highlighting their efforts to learn it. Alternatively, they can position themselves as defiant individuals who reject racism and their subservient

subject position and question the value of investing in English. As women move back and forth between these positions across the interviews to differing degrees, there is evidence of their struggle—often via discussions of language policy—to present themselves as acceptable or to justify their perceived 'wrongs' (i.e. being in the USA without legal documentation, being Latina, or speaking limited English). These positionings are significant for them as they are talking to researchers who are outsiders to their world and who present themselves as sympathetic, but who might also be perceived as sharing widely circulating opinions about immigrants and language behavior. The local relationship with the interviewer as an outsider and a member of the dominant culture underlies the need for this kind of identity work on the part of the women. As illustrated below, in this sense, there is an awareness of the broader, dominant anti-immigrant and pro-English ideologies outlined at the start of the article.

For instance, Jasmina's dialog with her interviewer emphasized the former of these identity strategies as she tends to present herself as a 'good immigrant'. In her direct answers to language policy questions she highlights her identity as a language learner and as one who has positive attitudes towards learning English (Excerpt 1). This point is expanded later in the interview (Excerpt 6); as we see below, in answering a question about whether there is popular support for a trial Spanish-language-education for bus drivers policy, she states that she does not see a great enthusiasm among the drivers for learning Spanish (lines 02–03).[2] However, rather than critiquing the drivers' lack of enthusiasm or the policy itself, she excuses their attitude as understandable and as being well within their rights. Instead, she suggests it is the Spanish speakers' duty to learn English.

Excerpt 1[3]

01	Jasmina	Porque en sí para mucha- o sea gente que es independientemente de
02		transportes y demás yo no les veo mucho la emoción o las
03		intenciones de querer aprender el español.
04	Int 2	Uh huh.
05	Jasmina	Pero bueno eso ya es cuestión de cada quien no? da igual nosotros estamos en su
06		país y también es nuestro deber aprenderlo! aprender su idioma.

01	Jasmina	Because really for many- I mean people who are independent of
02		transportation and all the rest I do not see them with much
03		excitement or intention to want to learn Spanish.
04	Int 2	Uh huh.
05	Jasmina	But well that is each person's choice right? It's the same we are in their
06		country and it is also our duty to learn it! learn their language.

Note how Jasmina places herself as part of a collectivity (*nosotros,* 'we' / *nuestro*, 'our') who needs to learn English because 'we' are in 'their' (*su*) country (lines 05–06). Attitudes towards English become a central means for her

to distinguish herself from others as she develops the argument across the interview that Latin Americans who live in the USA should learn English and contrasts herself with others who do not make this effort. Although not all were as explicit as Jasmina, many participants positioned themselves in similar ways.

In sharp contrast to this tendency to highlight efforts at 'fitting in' or 'doing their part' are the oppositional stances of participants such as Elisa. While Elisa is also responding to the same set of questions concerning language policy and touching on similar discriminatory or hostile practices she experienced, she uses this story as a backdrop to position herself as actively resisting a subjugated role. Elisa, in Excerpt 2 below, presents herself as actively involved in events and as an evaluator of this implicit policy and racist practice.

Excerpt 2

01	Int 1	Y has tenido algun conflicto acá con entre gente por no hablar inglés o entre
02		gente que solo+/. . . alguien te ha dicho una vez tienes que hablar inglés o algo asi?
03	Elisa	En Virginia cuando fui a dejar un dine+/. . . el dinero en la uh hace dos meses atrás
04		estuve en el bus y había una señora que hablaba no sé que me dijo en inglés no?
05		Y yo no le contestaba porque, y hay una persona que habla+/. . . una chica,
06		que habla español e inglés me dijo te esta riñendo porque eres latina me dijo y
07		estas son todas esas personas que son son de ahí del lado de Virginia de Arlington
08		no? De ese sector que están discriminando a los latinos.
09	Int 1	Uhu.
10	Elisa	Porque yo estaba sentada adelante y ella estaba atrás dice que yo le tapaba con mi
11		cabeza su cara y que no quería eso era.
12	Int 1	Uh.
13	Elisa	Yo no le había entendido no? y entonces seguía yo sentada pues que me
14		importa que me estará diciendo dije yo.
15	Int 1	Oh!@@@
16	Elisa	Yo no le estaba dando motivo y entonces dice y la otra dice esta riñéndote eso
17		es. Y yo le dije ah que ni y+/. . . Que le estoy haciendo a esta señora yo le dije?
18	Elisa	En ese bus dice va a todas riñendo.
19	Int 1	Uh.
20	Elisa	Son dos viejas que siempre están yendo en el bus y cuando se topa con alguna
21		latina que no le cae y andan riñendo no?
22	Int 1	Y qué estaba diciendo?
23	Elisa	Diciendo que no seas+/. . . que que vaya a otro lado a sentarse que no se siente allí a
24		su+/. . . a su delante->
25	Int 1	Oh! ((gasps))
26	Elisa	Sí asi.
27	Int 1	Wow!

01	Int 1	And have you had any conflict here with people for not speaking English or
02		between that only +/. . . Has anyone told you one time that you had to speak
		English or something like that?

03	Elisa	In Virginia when I went to leave some mo+/. . . the money at uh two months ago
04		I was in the bus and there was a lady who spoke I don't know what she said to
05		me in English and I did not answer her because- and there is a person who
06		speaks+/. . . a girl, who speaks Spanish and English she said she is fighting with
07		you because you are Latina she told me and these are all those people in who are
08		from there from that side of Virginia of Arlington, right? From that sector that is discriminating Latinos.
09	Int 1	Uhu.
10	Elisa	Because I was sitting in front and she was behind and she said that I was in her
11		face with my head and she didn't want it that was it.
12	Int 1	Uh.
13	Elisa:	And I didn't understand right? And so I kept on sitting down since what do I
14		care what she is telling me I thought.
15	Int 1	Oh! @@@
16	Elisa	I was giving her no reason and so she says and the other says she is fighting with you that's it.
17		and I told her uh that and+/. . . what am I doing to this lady I told her?
18	Elisa	In this bus she says she is fighting with everybody.
19	Int 1	Uh.
20	Elisa:	It's two old ladies who are always in the bus and when they encounter some
21		Latina that they don't like they start fighting, no?
22	Int 1	And what was she saying?
23	Elisa:	Saying that do not be+/. . . that go go somewhere else to sit do not sit there in- in
24		front of her ->
25	Int 1	Oh! ((gasps))
26	Elisa:	Yes like that.
27	Int 1	Wow!

Elisa responds positively to the interviewer's inquiry to whether she has been discriminated against for not speaking English. She presents herself here as resistant in two ways. First, by labeling the sector of Virginia where she was traveling as an area of discrimination (lines 07–08), she suggests that the (Virginian) women who mistreated her on the bus were in the wrong for being discriminatory and for 'starting fighting' rather than her being in the wrong for being Latina, being on the bus in that area, or speaking Spanish (lines 20–21). Second, by noting that she did not care at all about what the woman was saying (lines 13–14), she suggests that they (or their actions) were irrelevant. The overall effect conveyed to the interviewer an image of herself not so much as a victim of racist abuse or policy, but as clever and resourceful in resisting this abuse and putting the harassing women in their proper place in this telling.

For Elisa, this defiance against the pressure to learn English is linked to broader rejection of subservient status in the USA, a rejection that she explicitly discusses at many points in her interview. For instance, she also told in great detail of a negative encounter with her (former) employer in

which she reminded her opponent that 'here in this country. . .slavery does not exist. . .' (*aquí en este país . . . no hay esclavitud*). Thus, resistance to general pressure to learn English, at least for Elisa, is linked to resistance to subservient and racialized position in the USA. In making these points, Elisa could be said to be engaging in opposition to 'everyday racism' (Essed 1991: 261).

Looking more closely at the interactional positioning in the interviews with Jasmina and Elisa, in both excerpts above, although the interviewers' verbal responses were minimal, they were also supportive and sympathetic. However, it is also significant that there are differences between the two interviews. While the participants in the first interview had very recently met, the participants in the second had had many previous interactions and were very familiar with each other. Elisa and the interviewer clearly shared the idea that language discrimination against immigrants exists in the USA. This past relationship and common views might explain Elisa's confidence in expressing a more confrontational stance towards mainstream discourses about language use while Jasmina is more cautious. These two interview excerpts thus point to wide potential differences in participants' positions, experiences, and language ideologies, but also to how these shared positions are co-constructed and variable depending on the relationship between the interview participants.

Three frames for language policy

As the above excerpts highlight, interview questions about language policy at times evoked highly personal accounts of specific language experiences; these accounts, and the participants' roles within them, were shaped by salient circulating ideologies of language and immigration. At the same time, women's interpretations of 'language policy' (in Spanish, *política lingüística*) varied widely and with very few offering policy specifics. Given our participants' social isolation, it is not surprising that they seemed to have limited knowledge of language policy laws or initiatives (e.g. official English legislation, bilingual education policies, legal rights to medical translation, local initiatives to support access to public services). But this lack of information is also an important indication of how those most impacted by specific policies remain largely unaware of policy particulars but highly cognizant of broader language politics.

As suggested above, participants readily described concrete experiences with policies in their daily lives. Questions about *política lingüística* evoked a range of responses in part because *política lingüística* can be understood as both 'language policy' and 'language politics'. These questions also became occasions for personal sense-making and negotiation, suggesting women's isolation from public policy discussions and their exposure to conflicting messages in public and private domains. Concomitantly, discussions about Spanish became a terrain for reflections focused on language ideologies.

Most understandings of and orientations towards *política lingüística* were constructed by women within one of three frames, reflecting these conflicting experiences and expectations. These included: (i) *language policy as racism and discrimination against Spanish speakers*; (ii) *language policy as deception used to hide the government's objective to discourage immigration*; and (iii) *language policy as support services for Spanish speakers*. These different constructions often coexisted in the same interview. Their simultaneous presence reveals the extent to which Latino (im)migrants are confronted with conflicting public and private discourses about the value of Spanish and English as linguistic capital and the real (and imagined) role of these languages in their lives. However, the devaluation of Spanish, due to its perceived link to illegal migration noted above, is reflected in the prevalence of defensive stances observed in discourse sequences within all three frames.

Language policy as racism

All participants were quick to note the importance of English and problems inherent in being a monolingual speaker of Spanish in the USA. They repeatedly described English as essential *para mejorarse, defenderse,* and *superarse* ('to better oneself', 'to defend oneself', and 'to improve oneself'). Many began by stressing the need for English for basic communication, for 'survival', as well as for fitting in and belonging, avoiding humiliation, and gaining social status. While few women reported needing English for their current work or social lives, all women at some point indicated that the learning of English symbolized realized dreams of migration, job and educational opportunities. Yet, for many women, as for Lorena (Excerpt 3), language problems—and language policies undergirding them—were not directly the result of communication difficulties, but of racial discrimination. Language policy was interpreted in many cases as the implementation of discriminatory and racially motivated measures against Spanish speakers.

Excerpt 3

01	Int 2	Bueno usted cree que la gente+/. . . que hay una política del gobierno,
02		o de la ciudad del gobierno con con respecto al idioma al uso del español y el inglés?
03	Lorena	Yo pienso que esa política siempre ha habido. siempre (.) para+/. . . por el idioma por
04		muchas cosas. por raza discriminación más que todo de que (.)
05		cuando la gente no habla inglés, en los trabajos y en cualquier lado uno tiene
06		problemas siempre en el idioma. por eso el ingles es bien importante.

01	Int 2	Well do you believe that people+/. . . that there is a policy by the government,
02		or by the city with respect to language, to the use of Spanish and English?
03	Lorena	I think that this policy has always existed. always (.) for+/. . . for the language for
04		many things. because of race discrimination more than anything else that (.)
05		when people do not speak English, at work and in any other place one has
06		problems, always with the language. that is why English is very important.

Lorena cites racial discrimination (line 04) as linked with language policy, suggesting that Spanish speakers at work experience problems not because of communication difficulties but due to racial prejudice. Lorena then proposes learning English as one way of mitigating or avoiding racial problems.

Other women, such as Manuela below (Excerpt 4), turn to personal experience to elaborate on the links between language policy and discrimination.

Excerpt 4

01	Int 1	Y, y usted cree que hay una política del gobierno en cuanto al uso
02		del español y el inglés en lugares políticos o sea que qué piensan
03		los, políticos del español? Qué son las actitudes del gobierno?
04	Manuela	Uh (.) pues en algunos lugares dicen que le gusta que hablen bien
05		español pero en otros, en otros no! yo tengo una cuñada que
06		ella habla español, es americana, y yo fui a una clínica con ella y
07		ella me sirvió de intérprete y le dijeron allí la secretaria por que tu
08		hablas, ese idioma si no es tu idioma, como le dijo no tu no tienes
09		que hablar ese idioma, entonces ella- y ella le dijo que por QUE?
10	Int 1	Si claro.
11	Manuela	Porque le dijo que no que no era su idioma y que ella no tenía que
12		aprenderlo yo creo pues uh+/. . .
13	Int 1	Wow.
14	Manuela	Cosas de racismo tal vez de ver a la persona.

01	Int 1	And, and do you think that there is a policy by the government
02		with respect to the use of Spanish and English in political places
03		I mean what do, politicians think about Spanish? What are the attitudes of the government?
04	Manuela	Uh (.) well in some places they say that they like people to speak
05		Spanish well but in others, in others no! I have a sister-in-law
06		who speaks Spanish, she is American, and I went to a doctor's office with her and
07		she acted as an interpreter and they told her there the secretary why do you
08		speak, that language if it is not your language, like she said you should not
09		speak that language so she- and she told her WHY?
10	Int 1	Yes of course.
11	Manuela	Because she told her that it wasn't her language and that she should
12		not learn it I think uh+/. . .
13	Int 1	Wow.
14	Manuela	Racist things maybe just by looking at the person.

Here, Manuela interprets language policy as acceptance or rejection of one's right to speak Spanish in public places and declares that attitudes vary (lines 04–05). She then recounts a personal experience in which language policy is translated into concrete discriminatory action. Manuela describes a hospital visit during which the secretary challenged her sister-in-law's right to speak Spanish on the grounds that this was not the sister-in-law's language. For

Manuela, language policy, as expressed in this example of the statement by the clinic secretary, is a stand-in for racism, as she sums up in line 14. Her observation is supported implicitly by the interviewer's comments ('yes, of course' and 'wow', lines 10 and 13), both of which suggest outrage at the secretary's reported translation policy. In naming and describing these practices and policies, both Lorena and Manuela bring to light perceived injustices towards Latinos in the USA. Here and in many instances across the interviews, our questions about language policy evoked problematic experiences with English-speaking non-Latinos. While language often played a prominent role in such accounts, these experiences were widely interpreted as involving their being targeted due to racial, rather than linguistic, differences.

English language policy as deception

Language policy was also framed in the interviews as a tool of deception employed by the US government to obfuscate the presumed real objective of discouraging immigration and often linked to (long-stalled) immigration reform efforts. As many of the women had no legal authorization to stay in the USA, they tended to pay attention to immigration reform as it was covered on Spanish-language television and radio. As the last decade has seen much public discussion of immigration policy, but very few changes (Bacon 2008), skepticism and cynicism were pronounced among some of our participants, particularly those who needed greater cross-border mobility. As evident in the interview with Elisa below (Excerpt 5), for some, language policy was interwoven with long-held-out immigration reform policy.

Excerpt 5

01	Int 1	Y tu crees que hay una, ah una política del gobierno en cuanto al
02		uso, del español y del inglés?
03	Elisa	Sí.
04	Int 1	Qué será?
05	Elisa	Porque la política que están haciendo están poniendo el pretexto de la, del
06		inglés no ahora? porque hay muchos que hablan español inglés y que se
07		puede uno este+/. . . entender.
08	Int 1	Uh huh.
09	Elisa	Bueno en todo caso tendríamos que estudiar no si es que fuéramos legales,
10		por ejemplo yo tendría que tomar clases o sea esforzarme un poquito para tener un
11		poco de inglés,
12	Int 1	Uhu.
13	Elisa	Pero si fuera legal no? Por que si no soy legal y me tengo que ir a algún
14		lado para que necesito gastar el dinero en el inglés? @@@
15	Int 1	@@@
16	Elisa	Nunca me @@sale!
17	Int 1	No te va a ayudar!@@
18	Elisa	No me va a ayudar en nada me voy después para que me sirve el inglés?

01	Int 1	And do you think that there is a, uh, a policy of the government with
02		respect to the use of Spanish and English?
03	Elisa	Yes.
04	Int 1	What would that be?
05	Elisa	Because the policy that they are doing they are putting the pretext of the,
06		of English, now you see? Because there are many who speak Spanish
07		English and people can uh+/. . . understand each other.
08	Int 1	Uh huh.
09	Elisa	Well in any case we should study isn't it if we were legal,
10		for example I would have to take classes that is make some effort to learn a
11		little bit of English,
12	Int 1	Uhu.
13	Elisa	But if I were legal, right? Because if I am not legal, and I have to go somewhere
14		why do I need to spend money on English?@@@
15	Int 1	@@@.
16	Elisa	I can @@never speak it!
17	Int 1	It's not going to help you!@@
18	Elisa	It's not going to help me in anything, I leave and then what good does English do me?

For Elisa, language policy, viewed as the imposition of English learning, is framed as a pretext for delaying access to citizenship or legal residence. In light of this, Elisa positions herself as rejecting the vision of English as having general market value. She regards language learning as necessary or beneficial only for those who are granted legal status (lines 09–11). She underscores this point by making sarcastic remarks, shared with the interviewer and underscored with laughter (lines 12–17), on the fact that English is not going to help her if she is not in the country legally (lines 13–14 and 18).

Like other interviewees, Elisa rejects English language and maintains that she has little reason to invest in learning it. Furthermore, she experiences the pressure to learn English as punitive. She does not subscribe to mainstream discourses concerning the value of English, and instead sees it as a costly, labor-intensive investment with little reward given her legal status. Her (and others') interview talk suggests that restrictive language policies do not offer the incentives imagined by policy-makers (Crawford 2006). While this overt and repeated rejection of English learning can be linked to a broader oppositional stance (detailed above), it does not mean total rejection of English in practice. For instance, despite Elisa's strong stance, she laments that English is not taught more effectively in Bolivia and complains that she must pay 70 dollars a month for her college-age daughter to take English classes at a private academy.

Language policy as support services for Spanish speakers

As mentioned above, most participants had limited knowledge of particular language legislation and knew none by name; in a few cases, however, they

did indicate awareness of specific legislation in practice. For instance, Jasmina (Excerpt 6) notes that the city government tries to help Latinos by offering Spanish language courses to bus drivers.

Excerpt 6

01	Int 2	Y cree que hay una política del gobierno aquí con respecto al uso
02		del español y del inglés, uh (.) o no?
03		en los lugares públicos por ejemplo.
04	Jasmina	Bueno lo que yo tengo entendido que el gobierno está tomando
05		medidas para los, por ejemplo ayudar a los latinos de que eh (.)
06		por ejemplo los choferes de los autobuses están tomando cursos ya, para hablar
07		el español, entonces eso es algo bueno y hay que admirarles
08		eh esa iniciativa aunque en mi opinión digo bueno para mi no es
09		mucha ayuda porque me subo al autobús para practicar el inglés y
10		me hablan en español! entonces no es ayuda para mi para
11		ellos si pero para mi no.

01	Int 2	And do you think that there is a policy by the government here
02		with respect to the use of Spanish and of English, uh (.) or not?
03		In public places for example.
04	Jasmina	Well what I understand is that the government is taking
05		measures for the, for example to help Latinos that eh (.)
06		for example drivers of public buses are taking courses to speak
07		Spanish, then this is something good and one has to admire them
08		for this initiative although in my opinion well I mean for me it is
09		not great help because I get on the bus to practice English and
10		they talk to me in Spanish! so it does not help me it helps
11		them but not me.

Jasmina is among the few to give an interpretation of language policy as positive governmental intervention with respect to language minorities. She describes this policy tentatively as 'measures taken by the government to help Latinos' and orients moderately favorably to it ('something good and one has to admire them', line 07). However, she also judges the policy negatively as she frames these attempts to provide services to Spanish speakers as something not desirable to her personally since they limit her opportunities to practice her English (lines 08–10). It is notable that on the one hand, positive interpretations of language policy are rare in the interviews, while on the other, local government provisions that attempt to support Latinos seem to have gone mostly unnoticed, at least within this group.

CONCLUSION

The bulk of language policy work begins with the analysis of the texts, ideological assumptions, or political formations of specific language policies and

then possibly focuses on analysis of their effectiveness in meeting established goals. In contrast, here we have begun with the explicit or implicit targets of broader US language policies and politics—Latina (im)migrants. We then analyzed these women's reported experiences with and understandings of language policy and politics in the USA. Our analysis of this interview talk suggests three points.

First, our data illustrate how language policy is interpreted through women's own experiences rather than being influenced by public interventions or public media. These experiences involve, among other things, making sense of contradictory discourses concerning language, politics, and immigration and as a result, the women themselves express conflicting attitudes. For instance, they share the prevailing monoglot norm dictating the need to learn English in order to fit in and advance in the USA, but they also emphasize how they and their peers experience limited opportunities for upward social mobility or change in legal status, regardless of their investment in English. They also often experience attempts to push them to learn English as punitive and deceptive. In short, the data here thus illustrate how concrete life experiences shape individuals' understanding of language policy and often conflict with public discourses and intended policy outcomes.

Second, the discourse analysis of interview talk presented here suggests that greater attention is needed with respect to what language policies mean to the people most impacted by them. Such understanding can best be provided through the use of qualitative instruments such as case studies and interviews and through close analysis of a wide range of interactional talk. Indeed, we saw in our data that women use discussions of language policy as a platform for constructing alternative (positive) public identities within a generally hostile, anti-immigrant public climate. For instance, Jasmina frames her account of a local transportation policy in light of her own efforts to learn English, while Elisa uses a narrative about language conflict to position herself as someone who opposes discrimination. These examples demonstrate how discourse data and analysis can generate richer understanding of the complex and difficult to predict ways in which individuals relate to public decisions and public discourses.

Third, these data demonstrate how—at least within this population and context—understandings of language policy are intertwined with, or even subsumed by, immigration policy and politics. Language policy as a field has evolved rapidly over the past five decades (Spolsky 2004; Shohamy 2006), and scholars working in this area have devoted significant attention to the development of frameworks and rubrics for the analysis of language policy sub-areas, types, and goals. While this work has done much to define and advance the field on both practical and theoretical grounds, it has also segregated language policy from other areas of policy-making and analysis, such as immigration reform, economics, and public policy. As language policy became defined as a particular field of study, with its attendant assumptions, methodologies, frameworks, and internal theoretical debates, it also differentiated,

and to some extent, isolated itself from related social sciences. The present analysis reminds us of the importance of taking into account (non-linguistic) policy developments, not only in terms of thinking about language policy creation, but also—and more to the point here—in the interpretation of language policy by its intended targets.

Each of these points underlines how all questions concerning language policy are inextricably linked with local language ideologies and discourses, and at the same time, with inequalities of power. Indeed the data and analysis proposed here illustrate the many different ways in which language policy is interpreted by its targets, and point to the fact that what might impact people's perceptions and behaviors the most is *not* official policy itself, but rather the individual experiences and broader discourses that provide frames to make sense of this policy. Thus, the design and implementation of policies focused on language use alone—for example, the local initiatives to promote public access to services such as transportation discussed here—are unlikely to meet their intended aims without efforts to alter broader power relations and surrounding discourses.

SUPPLEMENTARY DATA

Supplementary material is available at *Applied Linguistics* online.

NOTES

1 These visa holders are, respectively, domestic workers for employees of international agencies such as the World Bank; for employees of embassies; and for foreign nationals and US citizens with permanent residence abroad who are allowed to import nannies, housekeepers, cooks, and other domestic workers from abroad. As many such visa-holders reside in the DC area, our sample includes a significant number of women with this status.

2 The DC Metro implemented in 2007 a pilot project to teach Spanish to bus drivers, station managers, and street supervisors in compliance with the Federal guidelines for language access (http://www.washingtonpost.com/wp-dyn/content/article/2007/10/24/AR2007102402523.html).

3 See Appendix 3 (available as online supplementary material) for transcription conventions.

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